

Roads? Where We're Going:

the movies promised me flying cars, so I kept score

Andi Sharkey, October 2026





Two questions

1. How far ahead do sci-fi films set their stories?

2. Now that many of those futures have arrived, how often were they right?

I built and scored it all by hand, then checked my own work (twice).



What I collected

233 released films, 1910–2026, each set in a named future year on humanity's current calendar. Every year is sourced.

- Released films only: cinema or streaming
- No invented calendars or alternate histories
- Ambiguous years flagged, never guessed
- Gap = setting year minus release year

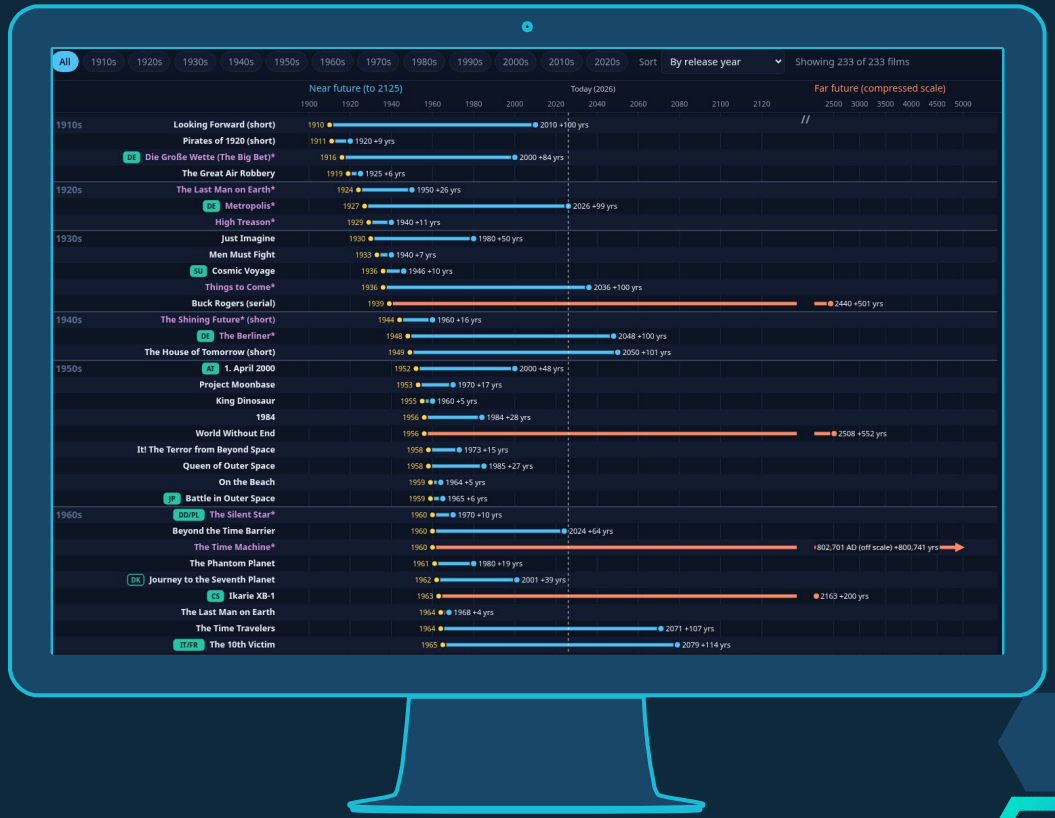
The timeline

Metropolis*
1927 to 2026 (+99), flagged

Back to the Future Part II
1989 to 2015 (+26)

The Time Machine*
1960 to 802,701 (off scale)

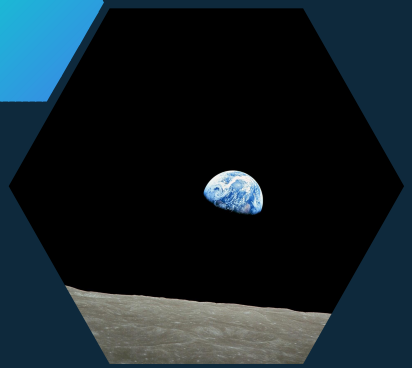
Interactive version:
oneredodd.github.io/scifi-timeline



34 years

median gap between release and setting year, all 233 films

The mean is meaningless here: The Time Machine (+800,741 years) drags it to 7,038 years. The median is the honest summary.



81

films (35%) of 233 are set in a year on or before 2026

Only these can be scored: each prediction is judged by the film's own setting year.

75 of the 81 have at least one scored prediction.

20.2%

score, counting near-misses as half (about 1 in 5)

11.4%

came true outright (about 1 in 9)

220

predictions scored, from 75 films

Judged by each film's own setting year; tech that already existed and plot devices excluded.



All three beat the average

35%

2001: A Space Odyssey
1968 to 2001

Hit: voice-print ID

Miss: Moon base

39%

Blade Runner
1982 to 2019

Hit: video calls

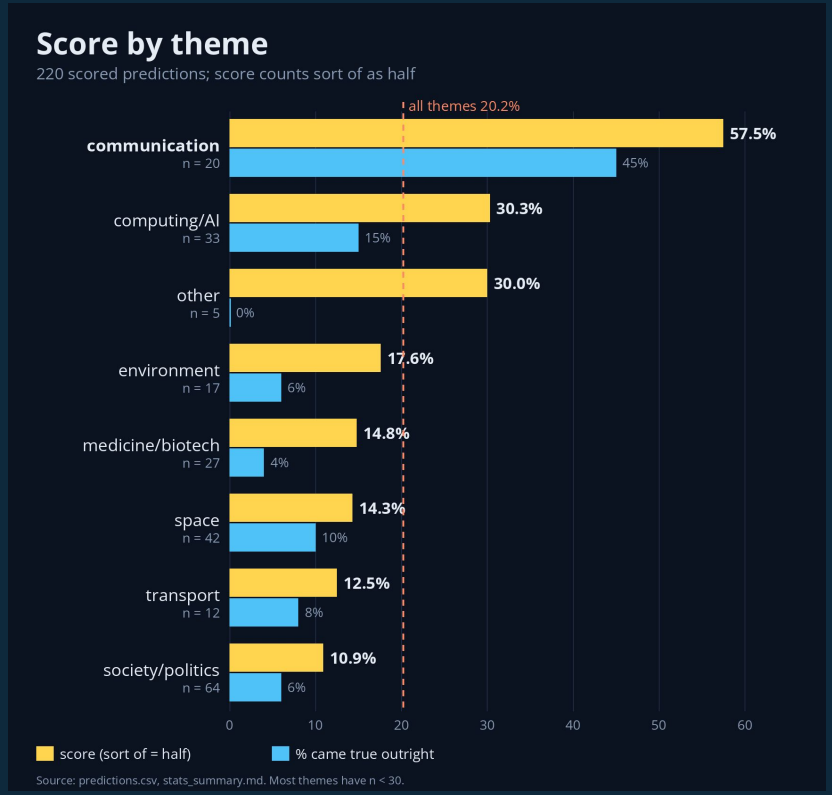
Miss: flying cars

45%

Back to the Future Part II
1989 to 2015

Hits: video calls, drones

Miss: hoverboards



Communication wins

57.5% communication: video calls, flat screens, voice control

30.3% computing/AI, next best

10.9% society/politics, lowest

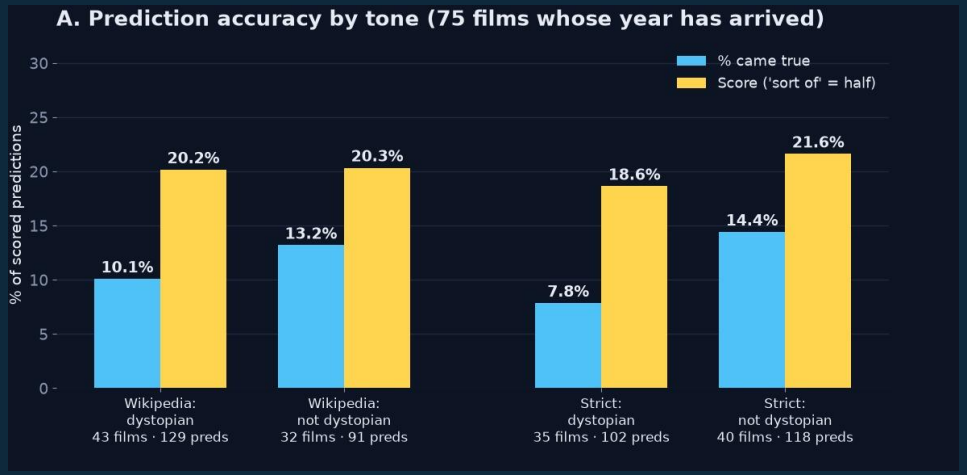
12.5% transport, from just 12 forecasts

Only communication survives a multiple-comparison correction.



Where’s my flying car?

Transport predictions scored 12.5% from 12 forecasts, and every flying car missed. Yet eVTOL air-taxi prototypes now fly: the function arrived, the form didn’t.



Bleak or bright?

18.6% vs 21.6% strictly dystopian films vs the rest (p = 0.14)

20.2% vs 20.3% on Wikipedia's labels (p = 0.52)

'Dystopias are rising' holds only on Wikipedia's generous labels

Gadgets right, catastrophes wrong: gadget forecasts scored 41%, but only 2 of 42 plagues, wars and collapses came true.

Bigger picture

	Wythoff & Leane	Mine
Scope	2,552 works, all media	Films only
Films	**960 (959 with a year)**	**233**
Film median gap	**25 years**	**34 years**
146 shared films	median 31 years	median 30.5 years

132 of the 146 shared films agree on the year: the gap is which films were picked, not how they were dated.

Data: Wythoff & Leane (2025), Post45 Data Collective, CC BY 4.0

Checking my work

Scoring

220 predictions from 75 films, each judged by the film's own setting year

Re-scoring

40 random predictions scored again from scratch: **39 agreed** (97.5%)

Two rounds of checks

Round 1: every number recomputed, every hit re-checked. **Round 2:** 44 later rows, 3 changed

Caveats: *famous films that name a year, not a random sample; one scorer; small groups. Akira's Olympics is coincidence, not foresight.*



Things I might look at later

Two things I've parked for now:

- Alternate history, set aside to look at on its own (e.g. 2009: Lost Memories)
- TV series: 94 already charted; I may score them later

Data, code and paper on the site:
oneredodd.github.io/scifi-timeline

Any questions?

